Response: Request for Information, AI Action Plan

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This document contains my (Adam Davies') response to the Request for Information on the Development of an Artificial Intelligence (AI) Action Plan issued by the National Science Foundation on February 6, 2025. All stated opinions, beliefs, and priorities are my own, and do not necessarily reflect those of any institution with which I am affiliated.

Response

In crafting the AI Action Plan, it is essential that the new Trump-Vance administration sustain and enhance our nation's AI dominance by advancing the following priorities:

1. **Maintain existing NSF awards.** Our nation has established and sustained a significant lead in foundational and applied AI technologies due in no small part to NSF-funded research. Given that a substantial part of the US' world-leading research ecosystem is supported by NSF awards, actions such as freezing, canceling, or otherwise hindering the disbursement of funds for existing awards will lead to a collapse in this critical ecosystem, carrying significant short- and long-term risks to our national security and economic competitiveness.

   Necessary policy actions:

   (a) Continue the lawful disbursement of funds for grants that have already been awarded.

   (b) Clearly communicate any new or updated criteria associated with the new administration's priorities with which grant holders and associated research activities should comply.

2. **Prioritize AI safety, security, and trustworthiness.** To promote human flourishing, economic competitiveness, and national security, it is essential that we understand, anticipate, and mitigate the safety and security risks associated with the development and deployment of foundational AI technologies. Failure to do so may lead to important vulnerabilities when deploying novel AI technologies that could be exploited by adversaries to attack domestic economic, financial, industrial, medical, educational, communications, or other critical institutions deploying these unsafe technologies. As such, the administration should prioritize both (1) advancing our foundational mechanistic understanding of how these models function internally, allowing us to better anticipate potential vulnerabilities; and (2) developing applied techniques to mitigate such vulnerabilities and improve safety, security, and alignment with respect to our goals and values.

   Necessary policy actions:

   (a) Prioritize available resources to support (1) foundational research in AI safety and mechanistic interpretability; and (2) applied research in AI safety, security, and alignment.